

Topic Reading - Questions

Nersisyan, Yeva; Liu, Xinhua; Wray, L. Randall (2023): The unbearable weight of aging: How to deal with the "demographic time bomb", Working Paper, No. 1018, Levy Economics Institute of Bard College, Annandale-on-Hudson, NY

Before reading:

1. Based on the title of the article (see above), what do you think it will be about?
2. When was the article published? Is it up to date?
3. Who published the article? Is this a reputable source?
4. Who wrote the article? Do the authors seem credible? Why/Why not?
5. Is there a good number of references? Are the references up to date? Are they academic?

Read the abstract and answer the questions below:

1. Which countries are cited as evidence that the global population is aging, and which issues are highlighted in those countries.
2. What do the authors argue? Do their argument surprise you in any way? Do you find their arguments convincing?
3. Would you describe the authors as pessimistic or optimistic about the future? Why?

Look at the headings and sub-headings from the article. Can you predict what each section will be about? Discuss with a partner.

1. INTRODUCTION
2. CHINA: THE CANARY IN THE COAL MINE
 - 2.1. Demographic Trends in China
 - 2.2. Global Demographic Trends

3. *IS THE BURDEN OF AGING REALLY A FINANCIAL PROBLEM?*

3.1. *Aging and the problem of finance*

3.2. *Is Social Security on an unsustainable path*

3.3. *Social Security is sustainable in terms of what matters*

3.4. *An alternative framing of the issue*

4. *CAN CHINA SUPPORT ITS AGING POPULATION*

5. *CONCLUSION: POLICY SOLUTIONS*

Read the text and answer the questions below:

Introduction

1. *What are the primary concerns about aging populations in various countries, as mentioned in the introduction?*

2. *According to the authors, why should we focus on resource provision rather than financial challenges in addressing the aging population?*

3. *How do the authors argue that falling fertility rates and an end to global population growth could be beneficial?*

China – The Canary in a Coal Mine

4. *What demographic trend in China is highlighted as a warning for other countries?*

5. *What are the anticipated impacts of China's aging population by 2035?*

6. *How did China's previous one-child policy influence its current demographic situation?*

Global Demographic Trends

7. *What similarities exist between the demographic trends in China and those in Europe?*
8. *Describe the demographic challenges faced by Japan and South Korea as mentioned in the text*
9. *What is the projected demographic composition of the United States by late this century?*

Solutions and Policy Adjustments

10. *What is the authors' perspective on the financial sustainability of social security systems in aging populations?*
11. *What policy recommendations do the authors make for handling the challenges of an aging population?*
12. *Why do the authors emphasize investments in physical and human capital over other types of financial adjustments?*

Analysis and Reflection

13. *What does the term "silver tsunami" refer to, and which country is cited as being at the forefront of this trend?*
14. *How does the concept of the 4:2:1 effect in China illustrate the challenges of an aging population?*
15. *What role does the authors suggest immigration might play in addressing labor force shortages in aging countries?*

Describing data

The article contains six “figures”. Take a look at each one with a partner and discuss what the figures depict. Then choose one figure and write a short description of what the figure shows and what the implications are.

Vocabulary

Look at a section of the article and highlight any words or expressions that could be helpful in your own writing.

Grammar

Think about an area of English grammar that you find difficult or that you would like to explore in more depth. For example: prepositions, use of articles, choice of tenses, complex sentences...Choose a section of the text and highlight all the examples you can find. Think about how the language feature is used and whether the authors had other choices.